

The Friends in Iran Dear Bahá'í Friends

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THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

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The Friends in Iran

Dear Bahá'í Friends,

9.1 We have received a letter from a believer in Iran with questions about the Guardianship and the Universal House of Justice. We appreciate that firmness in the Covenant is among the distinctive characteristics of the believers in that land, who are informed of the principles and essential facts pertaining to the succession of authority in the Cause. Nevertheless, none among them should hesitate to seek clarification of matters about which they have questions, for the enemies of the Faith are tireless in their attempts to sow seeds of confusion and doubt. Moreover, it is beneficial, in view of the beloved Master's exhortations to us all to be ever-vigilant concerning matters of protection, for the friends to review the relevant essentials from time to time. We have therefore decided to provide you with the following comments....

9.2 Questions concerning the Guardianship and the Universal House of Justice can be resolved through careful study of the writings of Bahá'u'lláh, 'Abdu'l-Bahá and Shoghi Effendi and the elucidations of the House of Justice, which, 'Abdu'l-Bahá states, will "deliberate upon all problems which have caused difference, questions that are obscure and matters that are not expressly recorded in the Book. Whatsoever they decide," He assures the friends, "has the same effect as the Text itself."

9.3 Prior to the passing of 'Abdu'l-Bahá in 1921, the provisions

He had put in place in His Will and Testament to safeguard

the Faith and ensure its steady advancement into the future

were generally unknown. The believers anticipated a day when

had been specifically mentioned in the Sacred Texts. There was, however, no definite understanding that there would be

a Guardian. Indeed, Shoghi Effendi later indicated that he had

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FRAMEWORK FOR ACTION no foreknowledge of the position to which he would be called.

At most, he had reportedly thought the Will and Testament

might charge him, as the eldest grandson of 'Abdu'l-Bahá, with

responsibility for arranging for the election of the House of

Justice. Only after the reading of the Will did the institution

of the Guardianship become widely known, and the Bahá'í community worldwide acknowledged Shoghi Effendi as the

Head of the Faith to whom all must turn.

9.4 An attentive reading of 'Abdu'l-Bahá's Will makes it clear

that He did not indicate a predestined outcome but did provide for a number of circumstances which, depending on future con -

ditions, might eventually confront the Faith. The second section of the Will, for instance, which refers only to the Universal

House of Justice, with no mention of the Guardianship, was written at a time when His own life was in imminent danger

and Shoghi Effendi was but a small boy. During that same

the threat on His life materialize. Through the grace of God, the

crisis passed, and it was ultimately left to Shoghi Effendi many

years later, as Guardian and Head of the Faith, to determine

the timing of the formation of the House of Justice. Early on he considered the possibility of holding the election soon after the

passing of 'Abdu'l-Bahá, in which case the House of Justice and

the Guardian would have functioned simultaneously. He deter -

mined, of course, that the foundations of the Administrative

Order needed first to be firmly laid at the local and national

levels, and it eventually transpired that the House of Justice was established several years after his own passing. That the can, itself, be attributed to the way certain provisions in the Will were formulated.

9.5 'Abdu'l-Bahá's Will and Testament clearly allows for the possibility of a successor to Shoghi Effendi, and in this light, we find statements written by him or on his behalf over the course of his thirty-six-year ministry that envision future Guardians.

However, there are no assurances in the Writings that the line of

Guardians would continue throughout the Dispensation; rather, the possibility is envisaged that such a line would come to an

end. In this respect, Bahá'u'lláh states in the Kitáb-i-Aqdas:

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Revealer of Signs. None hath the right to dispose of them

without leave from Him Who is the Dawning-place of

Revelation. After Him, this authority shall pass to the

Aghs.án, and after them to the House of Justice—should

it be established in the world by then—that they may

use these endowments for the benefit of the Places which have been exalted in this Cause, and for whatsoever hath

been enjoined upon them by Him Who is the God of might

and power. Otherwise, the endowments shall revert to the

people of Bahá who speak not except by His leave and

judge not save in accordance with what God hath decreed in this Tablet—lo, they are the champions of victory

betwixt heaven and earth—that they may use them in the

manner that hath been laid down in the Book by God, the Mighty, the Bountiful.

9.7 The passing of Shoghi Effendi precipitated the situation described, in which the authority vested in the Aghs.án—first

in 'Abdu'l-Bahá and then in Shoghi Effendi—ended before the House of Justice was established.

9.8 In His Will and Testament, 'Abdu'l-Bahá specifies in the

clearest terms the conditions according to which Shoghi Effendi

was to have named his successor as Guardian:

9.9 O ye beloved of the Lord! It is incumbent upon the

guardian of the Cause of God to appoint in his own life-time him that shall become his successor, that differences

may not arise after his passing. He that is appointed must

manifest in himself detachment from all worldly things,

must be the essence of purity, must show in himself the fear of God, knowledge, wisdom and learning. Thus, should the

first-born of the guardian of the Cause of God not manifest

in himself the truth of the words:—"The child is the secret essence of its sire," that is, should he not inherit of the

spiritual within him (the guardian of the Cause of God) and

his glorious lineage not be matched with a goodly character,

then must he, (the guardian of the Cause of God) choose

another branch to succeed him.

9.10 The Hands of the Cause of God must elect from their

own number nine persons that shall at all times be occupied

in the important services in the work of the guardian of the

Cause of God. The election of these nine must be carried

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FRAMEWORK FOR ACTIONNeither unanimously or by majority from the company

of the Hands of the Cause of God and these, whether

unanimously or by a majority vote, must give their assent

to the choice of the one whom the guardian of the Cause of

God hath chosen as his successor. This assent must be given

in such wise as the assenting and dissenting voices may not be distinguished (i.e., secret ballot).

9.11 The personal views of any individual regarding the above

statement, no matter how learned, cannot compare with the

Guardian's infallible understanding of the passage. Shoghi

Effendi, who faithfully adhered to the wishes of Bahá'u'lláh

and 'Abdu'l-Bahá throughout his ministry, would never have

been careless in a matter so essential to the integrity of the Faith as the question of the appointment of his successor. It is un-

thinkable that he would appoint someone to succeed him who

did not possess the qualifications laid down by 'Abdu'l-Bahá in His Will. It is equally untenable to suggest that he would do

so in a manner which deviated from the explicit requirements

in that same document, which included the affirmation of his

choice by nine designated Hands of the Cause of God, so that

“differences” would “not arise after his passing.” How perverse the suggestion of the violators of the Covenant that Shoghi

Effendi would ignore the Master's instructions and make a

veiled and indirect appointment of his successor! Rather should the fact that Shoghi Effendi did not name a successor be seen

as a sign of his meticulous adherence to every word of 'Abdu'l-

Bahá's Will and an indication of his conclusion that there was

no qualified individual whom he could appoint.

9.12 Therefore, it should be clear to every steadfast follower

of Bahá'u'lláh that the end of the line of Guardians was not

the result of any decision or action taken by the Hands of the

Cause of God following the sudden passing of Shoghi Effendi.

The line was brought to a close when, compelled by existing cir -

cumstances and the strict provisions of the Will, Shoghi Effendi

did not name a successor. To entertain the possibility that it

may one day be reestablished is futile. 'Abdu'l-Bahá wrote that

“ere the expiration of a thousand years, no one has the right to utter a single word, even to claim the station of Guardianship.”

And in the same passage He exhorted the friends, “Should

there be differences of opinion, the Supreme House of Justice

would immediately resolve the problems.” The Universal House

of Justice, soon after its formation, stated that it “finds that

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appoint a second Guardian to succeed Shoghi Effendi.”

9.13 While the line of Guardians has ended, the Covenant is

preserved. The vast body of interpretations of Shoghi Effendi

Faith continues its onward march. The unity of the Faith is safe-guarded, and the realization of Bahá'u'lláh's great purpose for

humanity assured. “The Hand of Omnipotence hath established

His Revelation upon an unassailable, an enduring foundation,” Bahá'u'lláh has stated. “Storms of human strife are powerless

to undermine its basis, nor will men's fanciful theories succeed

in damaging its structure.”

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9.14 With reference to the specific questions raised in the letter

we have received, one concerns the meaning of the designation

“Aghs.án,” as found in the Writings. While in some cases, as

affirmed by the Guardian, the term applies specifically to Bahá'u'lláh's sons, at other times it is used more broadly to

include His male descendants. For example, in His Will and Testament ‘Abdu'l-Bahá refers to Shoghi Effendi as “the chosen

branch”

(Ghus.n-i-Mumtáz). The reference to Shoghi Effendi as

Ghus.n here—the singular form of Aghs .án—follows the usage

of Bahá'u'lláh in relation to the titles He gave His sons, that

is, the Most Great Branch, the Greater Branch, and the Purest

Branch. A letter written on behalf of Shoghi Effendi explains

that the word Aghs .án “refers to Bahá'u'lláh's descendants”;

another describes Hussein Rabbani, the Guardian's brother, as

“the grandchild of the Master, an Afnán and A ghs.án mentioned

in the Will and Testament of the Master.” It is evident, then, that

the designation Aghs .án, or Ghus.n, includes Shoghi Effendi and

the other male descendants of Bahá'u'lláh.

9.15 If, at any time, male descendants of Bahá'u'lláh appear

who are faithful to the Covenant, it would nevertheless not

be possible for any of them to occupy the office of Guardian,

for, as already explained, in the absence of appointment by

Shoghi Effendi, they cannot claim the station of Guardianship

and there is no way for one to be named to it by an act of the House of Justice.

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FRAMEWORK FOR ACTION9.16 Another query concerns the establishment of the

Universal House of Justice. Specifically, the question has been

asked whether the functioning of an “officially recognized”

International Bahá'í Court in the Holy Land, mentioned by

Shoghi Effendi, was an essential preliminary step in the evolu-

9.17 As you are no doubt aware, Shoghi Effendi explained

that “Abdu'l-Bahá, Himself, in one of His earliest Tablets,

contemplated the possibility of the formation of the Universal

House of Justice in His own lifetime.” The Master described the

requirements necessary for its formation, which did not include

the establishment of a religious court:

9.18 The Supreme House of Justice should be elected accord-

ing to the system followed in the election of the parliaments

of Europe. And when the countries would be guided the

Houses of Justice of the various countries would elect the

Supreme House of Justice.

9.19 At whatever time all the beloved of God in each

country appoint their delegates, and these in turn elect their representatives, and these representatives elect a body, that

body shall be regarded as the Supreme House of Justice.

9.20 The establishment of that House is not dependent upon

the conversion of all the nations of the world. For example,

if conditions were favorable and no disturbances would

be caused, the friends in Persia would elect their represen-

tatives, and likewise the friends in America, in India, and

other areas would also elect their representatives, and these would elect a House of Justice. That House of Justice would

be the Supreme House of Justice. That is all.

9.21 Over the thirty-six years of his ministry, as he guided

the Bahá'í world, striving to lay the foundations of the Administrative Order, Shoghi Effendi outlined specific devel-

opmental steps to be taken, which were intended to lead to the accomplishment of some depended largely on the exertions of the believers themselves—an increase in the number of Local and National Spiritual Assemblies, the appointment of the International Bahá'í Council and its evolution into an elected body. Others, however, were subject to the forces operating in society and, no matter what the efforts made by the Bahá'í community, could not be accomplished.

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circumstances, under which the Bahá'ís of Persia and of the adjoining countries under Soviet rule may be enabled to elect their national representatives ... the only remaining obstacle in the way of the definite formation of the International House of Justice will have been removed.” Later, following the expulsion of Bahá'ís from Russia by the authorities, a letter written on his behalf explained, “At the time he referred to Russia there were Bahá'ís there, now the Community has practically ceased to exist; therefore the formation of the International House of Justice cannot depend on a Russian National Spiritual Assembly.”

9.23 In the same way, goals were specified by Shoghi Effendi for the establishment of Bahá'í courts, including national courts in certain countries in Asia and, as a step in the development of the International Bahá'í Council, the precursor to the Universal House of Justice, a court in the Holy Land. Recognition by the Egyptian government of the National Spiritual Assembly as an independent Bahá'í court was sought as far back as 1929.

Over time, changing conditions rendered the formation of such religious courts impossible. As the Hands of the Cause of God commented in 1959 in calling for the election of the International Bahá'í Council and the eventual establishment of the House of Justice,

9.24 We wish to assure the believers that every effort will be

made to establish a Bahá'í Court in the Holy Land prior to the date set for this election. We should however bear in mind that the Guardian himself clearly indicated this goal, due to the strong trend towards the secularization of Religious Courts in this part of the world, might not be achieved.

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9.25 Yet another question that has been raised concerns the tions previously performed by the Guardian. With regard to H.uqúqu'lláh, 'Abdu'l-Bahá has explained that "Disposition of the H.uqúq, wholly or partly, is permissible, but this should be done by permission of the authority in the Cause to whom all must turn." Likewise, the expulsion of Covenant-breakers is an obligation exercised by the Head of the Faith in the context of the duty to protect the Cause from those who would seek to un-

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FRAMEWORK FOR ACTIONdermine its unity. Shoghi Effendi, it is well known, was obliged to expel Covenant-breakers from the Faith at different points throughout his ministry, both before and after the appointment of the Hands of the Cause of God. This responsibility now falls whom all must turn. The current procedures followed in this respect are outlined in the statement "The Institution of the Counsellors."

9.26 In this connection it should be noted that after the passing of Shoghi Effendi, although overwhelmed with grief, the Bahá'í world maintained its unity during the tenuous period between

The sole challenge to its integrity appeared some two years after his death when Charles Mason Remey, who was at that time one of the Hands of the Cause, laid claim to the Guardianship.

As you are aware, Remey asserted that his appointment in 1951 as president of the nascent International Bahá'í Council meant that he should automatically assume the position of head of Guardian.

9.27 The absurdity of Remey's claim is obvious and requires

little elaboration. In 1957, he was among the Hands of the Cause who gathered in the Holy Land to consider what course of action should be taken following the unexpected passing of the Guardian. He personally affirmed that Shoghi Effendi had appointed no successor, signing a document issued unanimously by the Hands to this effect. As signatory to yet another such document, he agreed that the entire body of the Hands of the Cause would determine when and how the evolution of the International Bahá'í Council would culminate in the election of the House of Justice. For two years, as one of the nine Hands designated to serve in the Holy Land, he participated in the consultations that guided the development of the Bahá'í community. Then, without notice or discussion with his fellow Hands, he claimed the station of Guardianship, lacking explicit appointment by Shoghi Effendi as specified in the Will and Testament and in direct violation of the command of 'Abdu'l-Bahá that no one could make such a claim. Exercising the authority conferred on them in accordance with 'Abdu'l-Bahá's Will, the Hands of the Cause expelled him from the Faith as a Covenant-breaker.

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firm and steadfast; they should be wary, lest the arguments put forward by those who sow seeds of doubt become the cause for confusion or lead to disputation and disunity. Should questions arise that cannot be resolved, they should be placed immediately before the Hands of the Cause, who seek to shake the believers' faith. Whereas in the past the violators of the Covenant sought to undermine the authority of Bahá'u'lláh, 'Abdu'l-Bahá and Shoghi Effendi, today they undermine the authority of the Hands of the Cause and steadfastness in the Covenant but when they come across responsive ears they secretly sow the seeds of suspicion."

9.29 Remey's small band of associates, bedevilled by half a century of infighting among competing factions, have had neg-

ligible effect on the progress of the Faith. The flurry caused by their actions does nothing more than shake a few lifeless twigs and leaves from the tree of the Cause. Those who are naïve, those who are not deepened in the Teachings or not firm in the Covenant, those who are controlled by their egos and lust for leadership can be misled and fall away. The friends are urged to protect themselves and their community by adhering strictly to the emphatic exhortations repeated throughout the Sacred

Texts. As 'Abdu'l-Bahá states,

9.30 Unto the Most Holy Book every one must turn and whether unanimously or by a majority doth carry, that is verily the Truth and the Purpose of God Himself. Whoso doth deviate therefrom is verily of them that love discord, hath shown forth malice and turned away from the Lord of the Covenant. By this House is meant that Universal House of Justice which is to be elected from all countries, that is from those parts in the East and West where the loved ones are to be found, after the manner of the customary elections in Western countries such as those of England....

9.31 And now, one of the greatest and most fundamental principles of the Cause of God is to shun and avoid entirely the Covenant-breakers, for they will utterly destroy

the Cause of God, exterminate His Law and render of

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FRAMEWORK FOR ACTIONno account all efforts exerted in the past. O friends! It behooveth you to call to mind with tenderness the trials of His Holiness, the Exalted One, and show your fidelity to the Ever-Blest Beauty. The utmost endeavor must be exerted lest all these woes, trials and afflictions, all this pure and sacred blood that hath been shed so profusely in the Path of God, may prove to be in vain....

9.32 O ye beloved of the Lord! Strive with all your heart to shield the Cause of God from the onslaught of the insincere, for souls such as these cause the straight to become crooked

and all benevolent efforts to produce contrary results.

9.33 The believers in the Cradle of the Faith, who have with-

stood for more than a century the onslaught of government and

clergy, who triumphed over the perils posed by the rebellions of

Azal and Muh .ammad-‘Alí, who severed themselves from those

who opposed Shoghi Effendi, will easily discount the spurious and ridiculous arguments of those few individuals who vie among themselves to exploit Remey’s deviation as a pretext for

attracting a handful of personal followers. Be assured of our

supplications at the Holy Threshold on behalf of the beloved friends everywhere in that sacred land.

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]